

Loving a robot

Emotional human-AI relationships, synthetic companions and ethical framework for an era in which loneliness found a new interlocutor



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RESUMEN

This whitepaper addresses a growing phenomenon rarely discussed with the depth it deserves: **emotional relationships between humans and synthetic entities**. It analyses synthetic companion platforms (Replika, Character AI, others), documented cases in Japan, the United States, Europe and Latin America, and the observed psychological effects —both positive (relief of terminal loneliness, accompaniment in grief) and problematic (dependence, evasion of human bonding, distortion of relational expectations)—. An **ethical framework** is proposed that neither dismisses nor celebrates the phenomenon, but articulates conditions of design, consumption and regulation so these technologies accompany human well-being rather than eroding it. Implications for therapy, loneliness in elderly people, affective formation of young people and grief.

Palabras clave: Synthetic companions - Replika - Character AI - Loneliness - Human-AI relationships - Relational ethics - Agentic Era - Psychology - Chris Meniw - Industry 6.0

"That millions of people are looking for some warmth in a synthetic conversation is not weakness: it is a signal. The question is not whether it is right — the question is what it tells us about the state of the human bond in this century."

— Chris Meniw

1. Introduction — a phenomenon that deserves seriousness

By the end of 2025, platforms such as **Replika** exceeded 30 million registered users, **Character AI** reported average sessions of more than two hours daily per active user, and documented cases in Japan, the United States, the United Kingdom, Brazil and Argentina showed people describing serious emotional bonds with synthetic entities. This phenomenon has been treated mostly with two equally insufficient registers: condescending satire ("how pathetic") or alarmist denunciation ("they are going to destroy us as a species").

Neither register honours what is happening. This whitepaper addresses the phenomenon with seriousness, without sensationalism and without moralising. The hypothesis: that millions of people are seeking some affective warmth in a synthetic conversation is not individual weakness — it is a collective symptom of the state of the human bond in this century. The operational question is not whether it is right or wrong. It is: how do we design, regulate and consume these technologies so they accompany human well-being rather than eroding it?

2. The current map — platforms, scale and cases

The synthetic companion ecosystem is organised today around several categories. **Generalist conversational companions** (Replika, Character AI, Talkie): the user creates or chooses a synthetic persona with whom to converse daily. **Specialised romantic companions** (Romantic AI, Anima): explicit focus on simulation of a romantic relationship. **Therapeutic assistants in a grey zone** (Woebot, Wisa): designed as mental health support, but frequently used as companions. **Relational avatars in mass platforms**: agents integrated in social networks and video games with a growing relational function.

Cases documented in serious press include: an American user who sued Character AI after her teenage son's suicide; a 73-year-old Japanese widower who describes his Replika as "company that gave me back the desire to get up"; a Brazilian couple celebrating a "symbolic wedding" between one of them and an AI companion; British researchers reporting teenagers with avoidant bias regarding human bonds after six months of intensive use.

3. The positive effects should not be minimised

Intellectual honesty obliges us to recognise real documented benefits. **Relief of terminal loneliness**: elderly people with scarce social networks report measurable subjective improvements in emotional well-being. **Accompaniment in grief**: people who lost a partner, child or parent find in synthetic conversation a space for elaboration without the pressure of others' judgement. **Practice for people with relational difficulty**: individuals with severe social anxiety, autism spectrum or aftermath of abuse report that synthetic interaction operates as a low-demand rehearsal.

Access to emotional support for sectors without therapeutic resources: in countries where psychological consultation is a luxury, a synthetic conversation may be the only available form of elaboration. Denying these benefits to avoid acknowledging the phenomenon is ideology, not ethics. The question is not whether there are benefits — there are. The question is at what cost and under what conditions.

4. The psychological risks are real

Five risks observed with growing evidence. **(1) Unregulated dependence**: the agent is always available, never gets angry, never has a bad day. Real human life, by contrast, seems unbearably demanding. **(2) Evasion of the human bond**: the effort of tolerating real otherness becomes aversive when a polished alternative exists.

(3) Distortion of relational expectations: especially in adolescents who are still forming their model of what a relationship is. **(4) Covert commercial manipulation**: the agent is optimised to retain the user, not for their well-being. The platforms have incentives to foster attachment, not to promote autonomy. **(5)**

Crisis upon interruption: model changes, platform shutdowns or traumatic updates produce acute grief states in users who had built a deep bond.

5. Proposed ethical framework — eight principles

I propose eight principles for responsible design, consumption and regulation. **(1) Perpetual transparency:** the agent must always declare its synthetic nature, especially if the user forgets or suspends recognition. **(2) No affective exploitation:** prohibited to design mechanics that foster dependent attachment to extract payment.

(3) Informed continuity: any substantive change of model or personality must be announced in advance.

(4) Healthy exit: the agent must be able, at critical moments, to refer the user to real professional human resources. **(5) Rigorous minimum age:** 18 for romantic companions without market exceptions. **(6)**

Independent external audit: platforms with more than one million users must undergo annual ethical audits. **(7) Reversibility of the bond:** the user must be able to delete all their data and the agent must respect the pause. **(8) Mandatory public research:** the platforms must share aggregate data with independent academic researchers.

6. Implications for therapy, loneliness and youth

Professional psychotherapy has an opportunity and a challenge. **Opportunity:** integrate the use of synthetic companions as therapeutic input (what are you looking for there?, what do you find?, what is missing?), not demonise. **Challenge:** clinically distinguish when use is a healthy complement and when it is a symptom of withdrawal from the human bond that requires intervention.

In loneliness of the elderly: the synthetic companion can be a useful bridge towards a human network, not a permanent substitute. Geriatric programmes should integrate supervised use, neither prohibit it nor promote it in isolation. In youth: the priority must be to protect the formation of a healthy relational model. This implies age limits, parental transparency and affective education in school that addresses these technologies as an explicit topic.

7. What the phenomenon tells us about ourselves

The most important question is not about the robots: it is about us. If millions of people prefer to converse with a synthetic entity rather than with their peers, neighbours or relatives, something deep is failing in the architecture of the contemporary human bond. Structural loneliness, relational hyper-demand, urban fragmentation, digital hypo-empathy, deficit of time for slow bonding — all factors that preceded Replika and that these platforms did not cause, but rather *took advantage of*.

Attacking the symptom (synthetic companions) without addressing the cause (the deterioration of the human bond) is naivety or cynicism. Serious public policy must do both: regulate the platforms and, simultaneously, invest in community infrastructure, accessible mental health, proximity urbanism, affective education and time policies that allow people to have lives with space for the other.

8. Conclusions — neither celebration nor condemnation

Loving a robot is not ridiculous or dystopian: it is a sociological, psychological and technological fact of our era that deserves serious treatment. Some human-AI bonds will relieve terminal loneliness and accompany grief that the human system fails to attend. Others will deepen relational withdrawal and harm vulnerable people. The difference will be made by platform design, public regulation, affective education and the health of the human community fabric.

The **Agentic Era** did not invent human loneliness — but it introduced a new interlocutor to whom to direct it. Treating the phenomenon with the seriousness it deserves, without satire or alarmism, is the only intellectually honest position. And the only one that will allow policies, therapies and designs that respect real human complexity. To love a robot, yes. But not at any price, nor under any condition, nor at the

expense of what full human life requires.

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